No Boundaries

Computing is not something you do at a desk anymore, or just at work. All of us are computing on the move, and the future has more in store...

Robert Sovereign-Smith

Rewind a decade or two, to the *dark ages* when we were growing up (well, when I was growing up anyway), and today's world feels so alien at times. Had you gone about proclaiming then, that today we'd have Megabit access to the Net, full-fledged computers a little bigger than your palm, and mobile phones that can compute, game, surf, video call and more, you'd soon find yourself in a straight-jacket with padded walls aplenty!

Yet, here we are, exchanging data, accessing mail, surfing, gaming and computing on the move, from virtually anywhere. Although it seems to have all happened in the last 10 years, *Anywhere Computing* has been the goal for decades.

Shrikrishna Patkar

Laptops

The first mobile computer was probably the Grid Compass, designed in 1979 by William Moggridge from Britain. It was later used by NASA in their 80s space shuttle programme, because it was a fraction of the weight of any other computer of comparable computing power. It boasted of 340 KB of memory with a foldable display!

Soon after the Grid Compass, the Osborne 1 was released by Osborne Computer in 1981, and this is what most historians consider to be the first fully-functional laptop computer. It weighed about 12 kilos, had a 5-inch screen, a battery, two 5.25-inch floppy drives, a modem port and quite a few software applications. All that goodness came at a price though, about $1800 (a lot of money in 1981), and perhaps that explains why the company never successfully marketed the Osborne 1.

Today, we still pay premium for laptop computers, but it's not too much more than a desktop of a similar configuration. Most of us don't mind coughing up the extra dough for the convenience of being able to carry a PC wherever we go, and the market trends are proof of this... Over the last couple of years, the growth in sales of Laptops had risen exponentially, while the desktop market growth isn't what it used to be.

In this issue itself, we've tested laptops from various vendors, and you will find that all of them offer models that can sit on a single palm. Perhaps we might have to stop calling them notebook computers soon, and start calling them pocketbooks! As you will read in the test, small screens and tiny form factors don't mean special OSes and reduced processing power, instead, these little beasts are quite capable of handling anything you would normally do on a laptop.

PDAs

Going back to 1984 again, while most companies were still trying to figure out how to build cheaper and better PCs, with the occasional company attempting to build laptops, British-based Psion released the Psion Organiser I—a pocket computer. The Organiser I had 4 KB of ROM and 2 KB of RAM, with a single-row, monochrome, text display. It did not have an OS, and told time (and date), could calculate, and used a simplistic database—something like a shopping list that you type out in notepad; one item per line!

In 1986, the Psion Organiser II was released, and this was what we like to think of as the first real PDA.

The Psion Organiser II: perhaps the first true PDA

Intel's Personal Server / Agere BluOnyx

While everyone and their uncles are trying to make or envision flashy devices that promise to do your bidding at the click of a button, Intel took a step back and tried to solve one age old problem. Yes, it's true, you, me, your friends, other *Digit* readers, the world at large, we all have one common problem, "How do I carry all my data about with me?"

Let's use me as an example: My problem is, I have to leave all my music behind when I leave my house, or carry it all around with me on my external hard drive. For me, it's music, for you, it might be movies, videos, presentations, documents, whatever floats your boat. At the end of it all, we'll still find ourselves on a camping trip, or stuck in a cab, with all the data you require in an external hard drive and no way to get at it—at least not right now, when you need it the most.

The Idea behind Intel's Personal Server was that you needed a smart storage solution that powers itself and can interface with almost anything that you are near, with the right security measures, of course. Now instead of worrying about how to make a mini display, power it, make an interface, add features, and basically make another flashy device, Intel decided to leave that to those who do it best, and focus on making an extremely low power computer, that could store GBs, serve it all up over Bluetooth or Wi-Fi, and interface with any device that had a screen, a browser and a wireless connection—which is pretty much every desktop, notebook, cell phone and PDA today.

The idea was to carry the Personal Server in a bag, or your pocket, go wherever you wanted, and if you felt the need to get at your data, you could just whip out a cell phone, or borrow the phone of the guy in front of you in the queue to buy IPL tickets, use a browser to get at your files, edit them, mail them, or do whatever you normally would, had you been sitting at your home PC. The device, sadly, never made it out of Intel's labs, but chip maker Agere took the idea and released a prototype called BluOnyx, which is based on the same principle. Currently, BluOnyx is being sold as the world's first Personal Media Server, and you will find more details at **www.bluonyx.com**.